

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 30 Summary

Skool.com/qroo

These two prepositions often translate as “for” in English but are used in very different ways in Spanish. This lesson breaks them down into major categories so you can learn when to use each one correctly.

→ Purpose vs Cause

Use **para** to express **purpose**, intent, or destination.

Use **por** to express **cause**, reason, or motivation.

Example:

*Pusieron la cerca **para** los conejos.* = They put up the fence **for** the rabbits (as a favor to them).

*Pusieron la cerca **por** los conejos.* = They put up the fence **because of** the rabbits (to keep them out).

Another example with *por* meaning “because of”:

*Juan lloró **por** lo que pasó ayer.* = Juan cried **because of** what happened yesterday.

→ To Work For Someone

Use **para** if you work **as an employee** for someone.

Use **por** if you work **because of** or **on behalf of** someone.

Example:

*Trabajo **para** ella.* = I work for her (she's my boss).

*Trabajo **por** ella.* = I work because of her (she's my motivation, or maybe she's sick and I'm filling in).

→ In Order To (Infinitive Purpose)

Use **para + infinitive** when expressing purpose. You can often mentally insert “in order to” in English.

Examples:

*Me levanto temprano **para** evitar el tráfico.*

*Juan me mandó un mensaje **para** decirme que llegaría tarde.*

*He ahorrado dinero por tres años **para** comprar una casa.*

➡ Exception: Verb IR

After verbs of motion like **ir**, it's more common to use **a + infinitive** than *para*.

Examples:

*Fui a la tienda **a** comprar pan.* = I went to the store to buy bread.

*Fui **a** comprar pan a la tienda.* = Same idea, just reordered. Still uses **a**.

➡ PARA QUE + Subjunctive

If you introduce a new subject with **para**, it becomes **para que**, and the verb that follows must be in the subjunctive.

Example:

*Le regalé flores a mi mujer **para que** supiera que la amo.*

= I gave my wife flowers so that she would know I love her.

➡ Direction and Movement

Use **por** to describe movement **through** or **around** a place.

Use **para** to describe **destination**.

Examples:

*El pájaro entró **por** la ventana.* = The bird came in **through** the window.

*María salió **para** Estados Unidos.* = María left **for** the U.S.

*Ese es el tren **para** Madrid.* = That's the train **to** Madrid.

➡ Exchange or Substitution

Use **por** to express exchange or substitution.

Examples:

*Cambié la llanta rota **por** otra.* = I exchanged the flat tire for another one.

*Quiero cambiar mi coche **por** uno más rápido.* = I want to trade my car for a faster one.

Pagar + Por

In English, we always say “pay for.” In Spanish, **pagar** sometimes includes the idea of “for” and sometimes doesn’t.

Examples:

*¿Quién pagó **por** la computadora?*

¿Quién pagó la computadora?

*Pagué mucho **por** la casa.*

*Pagué 300 dólares **por** dos lámparas.* (B is needed here because the item paid for doesn't follow immediately after the verb.)

Stick to this rule: if you separate the item from *pagar*, use **por**.

Time Expressions

Use **por** when referring to how long something lasted.

Example:

*Hablamos **por** tres horas.* = We talked for three hours.

Use **para** when referring to a due date or deadline.

Example:

*Necesito el informe **para** el viernes.* = I need the report by Friday.

Passive Voice with SER

Use **por** after **ser + past participle** to show who did something (passive voice).

Example:

*La ciudad fue construida **por** los españoles.* = The city was built by the Spanish.

➡ Verbs Commonly Used with POR

Some verbs are almost always used with **por**. Example:

Preguntar por = to ask about/for

*Fui a recepción a preguntar **por** la llave de mi habitación.*

Note: *Pedir* and *buscar* already include the meaning “for,” so they don’t need a preposition.

Example:

¿Pediste la cuenta? = Did you ask for the check?

Busco mis llaves. = I’m looking for my keys.

➡ PARA + People (For Me, For You)

Use **para** to express “for me,” “for you,” especially when ordering food or giving something to someone.

Examples:

Para mí, una ensalada. = For me, a salad.

Para mi amigo, una hamburguesa. = For my friend, a hamburger.

➡ PARA for Benefit or Effect

Use **para** to express the benefit or effect of something.

Examples:

*Fumar es malo **para** la salud.* = Smoking is bad for your health.

*Es bueno **para** los niños.* = It’s good for the kids.

Final Thoughts

This is one of the longest and most nuanced lessons in Spanish. Por and para each cover many different ideas and categories, so don’t expect to master them all at once. Revisit this lesson often and focus on learning one pattern at a time. With consistent exposure and repetition, it will start to feel natural.